A Shipwreck That May Be the World's Oldest

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Archaeologists may have found the world's oldest shipwreck. Based on clues from its cargo, including pottery, a research team has **tentatively** dated the wreck to around 2700-2400 BCE. But much work remains, and no paper has been published in a **peer-reviewed** journal yet.

Associate Professor Hakan Öniz of Akdeniz University, Antalya, found the wreck in shallow waters off Kekova, west of Antalya in Turkey, in 2024. He followed clues from local seafarers.

Nothing is left of the ship. What remains is its cargo, stuck in the rocky slope along the Kekova coast. The ship now rests on the **seabed** between two islands. The team thinks it likely hid in calmer lee waters during a storm while sailing along the coast of southern Turkey.

Over the past four months, divers pulled pottery from barnacles on the rocky underwater slope. The cargo included large ceramic storage jars called **amphorae**, which once held products from the eastern Mediterranean.

If the dating is right, the find could change what we know about ancient Mediterranean connections during the Early Bronze Age, around 4,500 years ago.

Word Treasure

Archaeologists -- People who dig up and study old objects to learn about people from long ago.

tentatively -- In a way that is not yet certain and may change when more is learned.

amphorae -- Large ceramic jars used long ago to store and carry things like food and drink.

seabed -- The ground at the bottom of the sea.

peer-reviewed -- Checked by other experts in the same subject before it is published.

Background you need

Long ago, traders sailed wooden ships around the Mediterranean Sea to carry goods between far-apart places.

When a ship sank, its cargo could stay on the sea floor for a very long time.

Today, divers and researchers study what is left to learn how people traded and traveled in the past.

Break it down

WHO: Hakan Öniz of Akdeniz University, Antalya, and his research team, with help from local seafarers.

WHAT: A possible world's oldest shipwreck, of which only its cargo remains.

WHERE: In shallow waters off Kekova, west of Antalya in Turkey, on the seabed between two islands.

WHY: Because if the dating is right, the find could change what we know about ancient Mediterranean connections during the Early Bronze Age.

Why it matters

It is like finding an old storage jar under the sea that can tell you what people carried and traded long before you were born.

Test what you remember

1. To around when has the research team tentatively dated the wreck?

- (A) Over the past four months
- (B) Around 4,500 years from now
- (C) Around 2700-2400 BCE
- (D) In 2024

2. Where was the wreck found?

- (A) On a beach in England
- (B) In a lake in China
- (C) In shallow waters off Kekova, west of Antalya in Turkey
- (D) In deep waters far from land

3. What is left of the ship itself?

- (A) Nothing
- (B) Its crew's cabins
- (C) Its sails
- (D) Its wooden hull

4. What did the cargo include?

- (A) Gold coins
- (B) Iron anchors
- (C) Large ceramic storage jars called amphorae
- (D) Wooden boxes of books

5. What does the team think the ship likely did during a storm?

- (A) Dropped its cargo overboard
- (B) Turned back home at once
- (C) Hid in calmer lee waters
- (D) Sailed out to open sea

6. What has not happened yet for this find?

- (A) Clues have been followed from local seafarers
- (B) Divers have pulled pottery from the slope
- (C) The wreck has been found
- (D) A paper has been published in a peer-reviewed journal

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. The research team: The team thinks the ship likely hid in calmer lee waters during a storm while sailing along the coast of southern Turkey.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):